

You have to challenge existing businesses. You have to be an outsider. You have to come up with something new or a new way of doing things or just a better way of doing things in an old industry.

Does that mean you have to try something really wild and weird? Not at all. Another old friend, Mark Ford, has studied the issue for many years. He's probably the world's leading expert on how new businesses are created, built, and developed into substantial enterprises. He points out that most successful entrepreneurs are not risk takers. They are interested in building businesses, not in gambling. They know that what they are trying to do—create a new business—is a risky undertaking. But they try to minimize the risk by following very sensible, conservative rules.

For one thing, Mark says they always stick to a fundamental rule:

ONE STEP AT A TIME

The idea is very simple. You begin very small. You try a number of things. If you're lucky, you'll find something that works before you run out of time, money and confidence. It may be a small thing. But it has to pay the bills. It has to generate enough money to keep the lights on and allow you to try other things.

In our business, we began with a single newsletter. In 1978, we figured there were lots of Americans who would be interested in opportunities overseas . . . not for tourism, but for deeper, longer experiences. We started a newsletter called *International Living*.

Until that time, the elder Bonner worked at a small public-interest group in Washington, the National Taxpayers Union. When he started, in 1973, he earned \$100 per week. When he left, in 1978, he was earning (from memory) about \$60,000 per year as executive director of the group. It was good money back then. But he had ambitions that went beyond what he could get from a job, and he was beginning to wonder about “public service,” generally. He had worked to reduce taxes and government spending. Despite his best efforts, government spending was going up. It looked like he was fighting the tides of history.